Scholar Allison Busch has demonstrated that in this Brajbhasha epic, when the prosaic and sordid truth failed to match up to exalted literary ideals of what a hero should look like, Keshavdas allowed the readers to see alternative truths that arose, inevitably, from the seam of discord in the poet's mind. In the new reality where Mughal might now controlled the destiny of Orchha and Bundelkhand, Keshavdas not only wrote of Bir Singh's unwillingness to carry out the murder, but also portrayed Abu'l Fazl in glowing terms, and described with empathy and tenderness the Padshah's deep sorrow upon learning of the death of his old friend:

> Spoke Khan Azam consoling words
> Which the emperor could not discern
> Azam exhausted himself consoling the emperor
> Who understood not a word
> Who understood not a word
> His eyes streamed like clouds releasing rain
> Says Keshav, the cloud burst forth with maddening grief
> How could the flooding ocean of the emperor's grief be contained?
> Whoever tried to console the emperor over and over,
> Exhausted himself with the words he spoke.

The account of the inconsolable grief of Akbar at the death of Abu'l Fazl is borne out by Persian sources. The author of the *Maasir ul-Umara* states that reports of the deaths of royal princes were never announced aloud but were wordlessly signalled through the wearing of a blue armband. So, too, for Abu'l Fazl, since no courtier dared to announce the devastating news to the Padshah directly. Shaikh Farid Bakshi Beg wore a blue armband and bowed before Akbar who was watching his beloved pigeons tumble through the sky. The Padshah took one look at the dreaded armband, uttered a loud cry, and fell to the ground unconscious. For several days Akbar was utterly grief-stricken, weeping and piteously telling Asad Beg[*] 'if Salim wished to be Emperor he might have killed me and spared Abu'l Fazl'. He was extremely grieved, disconsolate, distressed, and full of lamentation' wrote a shaken Asad Beg who was present at court. 'That day and night he neither shaved, as usual, nor took opium, but spent his time in weeping and lamenting.' Akbar wept for many days and 'severely censured the prince for what he had done, and often blamed him'. According to Inayatullah, who completed the *Akbarnama* after the death of Abu'l Fazl, Akbar never in his